Horizon University

Digital Horizon Initiative

Request for Proposal: Internship and Practicum Management System

RFP identifier: DH-05 **Client office:** Career Development and Experiential Learning Office

Project type: Independent software initiative

Status: Open for discovery and solution proposal

1. Institutional context

Horizon University includes internships, professional practices, clinical or field placements, and other work-integrated learning activities in several academic programs.

These experiences may take place in:

- Private companies.
- Government agencies.
- Nonprofit organizations.
- Research centers.
- Schools and community organizations.
- University departments.
- Remote or hybrid work environments.

The Career Development and Experiential Learning Office coordinates these activities with academic programs, students, host organizations, faculty supervisors, and workplace supervisors.

Current coordination relies heavily on:

- Email.
- Spreadsheets.
- Online forms.
- Shared folders.
- Independent records maintained by academic programs.
- Documents exchanged directly between students and employers.

Although these practices allow placements to proceed, the university does not have a consistent source for determining the status of an internship application, placement, supervision process, or final evaluation.

2. Current problem

The office has identified several recurring difficulties:

- Internship opportunities are distributed through different channels.
- Students cannot easily determine which opportunities match their program or eligibility.
- Companies receive applications in inconsistent formats.
- Academic approval and employer selection are not clearly coordinated.
- Required agreements and documents are tracked manually.
- Students may begin work before every institutional requirement is complete.
- Placement start and end dates may differ from academic-period dates.
- Supervisors do not always complete evaluations on time.
- Faculty supervisors have limited visibility into workplace progress.
- Students may not know whom to contact when difficulties arise.
- Changes in supervisor, schedule, location, or assigned responsibilities are not consistently recorded.
- Internship hours and progress evidence may be difficult to verify.
- Host organizations may access more student information than necessary.
- Academic programs prepare completion and placement reports manually.
- The university cannot easily identify delayed, at-risk, interrupted, or incomplete placements.
- Final completion may be recorded even when required evidence is missing.

The university wants to improve this process without building a complete recruitment platform, payroll system, or learning-management system.

3. Business objective

Horizon University seeks a software solution that supports the lifecycle of internships and professional-practice placements.

The intended solution should help the university:

- Register and publish internship opportunities.
- Support student applications.
- Validate student eligibility.
- Coordinate employer selection and academic approval.
- Manage required agreements and documents.
- Activate approved placements.
- Track supervision, progress, hours, and evaluations.
- Record important changes or incidents.
- Support communication among relevant stakeholders.
- Monitor deadlines and incomplete actions.
- Protect student and employer information.
- Produce operational reports.
- Preserve a traceable history from opportunity publication through placement closure.

The consulting team is expected to investigate the existing process and propose an appropriate solution.

4. Initial stakeholders

The consulting team should initially consider the following stakeholder groups.

Students

Students explore opportunities, submit applications, complete requirements, participate in placements, provide progress evidence, and review evaluations.

Host organizations

Companies and other external organizations publish or confirm opportunities, review candidates, appoint workplace supervisors, and evaluate student performance.

Workplace supervisors

Supervisors assign activities, monitor student performance, approve progress evidence, and complete evaluations.

Faculty supervisors

Faculty members monitor academic progress, review reports, communicate with workplace supervisors, and address academic concerns.

Academic program coordinators

Program coordinators validate eligibility, approve placements, and determine whether the experience satisfies program requirements.

Experiential-learning coordinators

Administrative personnel manage opportunities, documents, agreements, deadlines, placements, and institutional reporting.

Legal or institutional-agreement representative

Some placements require review of agreements, insurance, confidentiality, or institutional conditions.

Information Technology Services

IT Services is concerned with authentication, privacy, external access, integration, maintainability, and technical support.

Additional stakeholders may emerge during discovery.

5. Initial process description

The current process generally operates as follows:

1. A host organization communicates an internship opportunity.
2. The university reviews whether the opportunity is appropriate for students.
3. The opportunity is shared with eligible students.
4. A student submits an application or expresses interest.
5. The student's academic eligibility is reviewed.
6. The employer reviews candidates.
7. The employer selects or rejects applicants.
8. The academic program evaluates whether the proposed placement satisfies program requirements.
9. Required agreements, insurance, confidentiality forms, or other documents are prepared.
10. The placement is approved and activated.
11. The student begins the internship.
12. During the placement:
    - Hours or activities may be recorded.
    - Progress reports may be submitted.
    - Faculty and workplace supervisors may communicate.
    - Evaluations may occur.
    - Problems or changes may be reported.
13. The workplace supervisor submits a final evaluation.
14. The student submits required final evidence.
15. The faculty supervisor or program coordinator confirms completion.
16. The placement is closed.

This description is incomplete and should not be treated as a final requirements specification.

The consulting team is expected to investigate:

- Which placement types exist.
- Who may publish opportunities.
- How eligibility is determined.
- How applications are handled.
- Which approvals are required.
- Which documents must be completed before activation.
- How supervision and progress should be recorded.
- Whether hours must be tracked.
- How evaluations should work.
- What happens when a placement changes or experiences problems.
- Which information external employers may access.
- Which evidence is required for final completion.
- Which reports are valuable to the university.

6. Expected value

A successful solution should provide value in at least four areas.

Student experience

Students should understand available opportunities, eligibility, application status, placement requirements, deadlines, and next actions.

Employer coordination

Host organizations should be able to communicate opportunity and evaluation information without receiving unnecessary access to university records.

Academic oversight

Faculty supervisors and academic programs should be able to monitor whether placements remain educationally appropriate and whether required evidence has been completed.

Institutional accountability

The university should be able to reconstruct important applications, approvals, agreements, evaluations, changes, and completion decisions.

7. Known constraints

The proposed solution must respect the following constraints:

- Only synthetic student, employer, and placement information may be used.
- Institutional users should authenticate through the university identity service or a simulated equivalent.
- External users must receive controlled and limited access.
- Access must depend on role and relationship to the opportunity or placement.
- Sensitive student evaluations and employer information must be protected.
- Important approvals, evaluations, and placement changes must be traceable.
- The solution must operate independently of other student projects.
- Integration with student, identity, document, and academic systems may be simulated.
- The university has limited technical personnel and prefers maintainable solutions.
- The system should support remote and hybrid participation.
- The project must remain feasible within one semester.
- Program-specific eligibility and completion rules must be capable of changing.
- The system must not process payroll or real financial transactions.
- Students must not begin a placement before mandatory activation conditions are satisfied.

8. Initial operational assumptions

Teams may begin with the following approximate environment:

- Approximately 12,000 undergraduate students.
- 600–900 internship or practicum placements per year.

- 200–300 participating host organizations.
- 8–12 experiential-learning personnel and program coordinators.
- 60–100 faculty supervisors.
- Most placements last between 8 and 24 weeks.
- Some programs require a minimum number of hours.
- Some placements are paid, while others are unpaid.
- Opportunities may be competitive or directly arranged by students.
- A workplace supervisor normally oversees one or more students.
- A faculty supervisor may monitor several active placements.
- Demand and placement activation increase near the beginning of academic periods.

These figures are preliminary and may be clarified during stakeholder consultation.

9. Expected project capabilities

The university expects the final project to demonstrate at least one complete end-to-end placement workflow.

The solution may need to support capabilities such as:

- Host-organization registration.
- Internship-opportunity registration.
- Opportunity review and publication.
- Student application.
- Eligibility validation.
- Employer selection.
- Academic-placement approval.
- Required-document checklist.
- Agreement-status tracking.
- Placement activation.
- Supervisor assignment.
- Work-plan registration.
- Progress reporting.
- Hours or activity tracking.
- Supervisor feedback.
- Midterm and final evaluation.
- Change or incident reporting.
- Deadline reminders.
- Placement completion and closure.
- Search and filtering.
- Operational dashboards.
- Placement history.

This list identifies possible business needs. It does not prescribe the complete feature set or architecture.

The team must prioritize and justify the capabilities included in its agreed scope.

10. Out of scope

Unless later clarified by the stakeholder, the project is not expected to:

- Replace commercial recruitment platforms.
- Process employee payroll.
- Calculate taxes or employment benefits.
- Manage complete human-resources processes for employers.
- Guarantee employment after the internship.
- Perform background checks.
- Replace the university's learning-management system.
- Calculate official final course grades.
- Manage every type of clinical licensure or certification.
- Process real insurance claims.
- Store real employment contracts.
- Monitor student location continuously.
- Record employee surveillance information.
- Use artificial intelligence to select candidates automatically.
- Manage all university alumni employment services.

Simulated integrations may be used where necessary.

11. Expected consulting response

During the Project Foundation and Business Discovery phase, the consulting team should produce evidence demonstrating:

- Understanding of the internship and practicum process.
- Identification of relevant stakeholders.
- Analysis of the current process.
- Proposed process improvements.
- Initial project scope.
- Functional and quality requirements.
- Assumptions and unresolved questions.
- Initial backlog.
- Preliminary risks.
- Initial success criteria.

The team should not commit to a detailed architecture before completing sufficient discovery.

12. First stakeholder consultation

Before the first stakeholder meeting, the team must prepare focused questions concerning:

- Placement types.
- Eligibility.
- Opportunity publication.

- Student-arranged placements.
- Employer selection.
- Academic approval.
- Agreements and required documents.
- Placement activation.
- Supervision.
- Hours and progress evidence.
- Evaluations.
- Changes and incidents.
- External-user access.
- Completion requirements.
- Reporting.
- Success criteria.

The stakeholder should not be asked to select programming languages, databases, frameworks, or architecture styles.